

Why your charging bill is bigger than the app said

By [your name]

The first time it happened I assumed I'd misread the app.

I plugged in on a side street off the Overtoom, went for lunch, came back about two hours later and the total was a few euros more than I'd worked out in my head. Not a disaster. Just annoying, and vague enough that I couldn't be bothered to chase it.

Then it happened in Utrecht. Then in Haarlem, where it was worse.

What I eventually figured out

A charging bay inside a paid parking zone is still a paid parking space.

That's the whole thing. The electricity is metered, priced, and shown to you. The ground your car is standing on while it charges is billed separately at the normal municipal hourly rate, and nothing at the charge point says so. Two systems, neither of them knows the other exists.

I started writing it down. Date, location, kWh, what the app said, what actually came off the card. After a few months I had a spreadsheet and a fairly clear idea that I was not imagining it.

The spreadsheet got out of hand. There are 196,151 public charge points in this country and the parking tariffs live in separate municipal decisions, one per city, published as PDFs that nobody ever intended anyone to compare. So I stopped keeping a spreadsheet and built the thing properly instead.

The numbers

Take a normal stop. Twenty kWh over two hours, which is a top-up while you do something else, not a full charge.

The electricity costs €8.20 at the national median of €0.41 per kWh. That part barely moves. The parking is what changes, and it changes a lot.

CITY	PARKING, 2 HRS	TOTAL	PARKING'S SHARE
Delft	€7.28	€15.48	47%
Utrecht	€7.16	€15.36	47%
Haarlem	€6.98	€15.18	46%
The Hague	€6.40	€14.60	44%
Amsterdam	€6.00	€14.20	42%
Nijmegen	€5.80	€14.00	41%
Zwolle	€5.46	€13.66	40%

CITY	PARKING, 2 HRS	TOTAL	PARKING'S SHARE
Groningen	€4.50	€12.70	35%
Maastricht	€4.34	€12.54	35%
Rotterdam	€4.00	€12.20	33%
Breda	€4.00	€12.20	33%
Tilburg	€4.00	€12.20	33%
Leiden	€3.80	€12.00	32%
Eindhoven	€3.00	€11.20	27%

So in Delft nearly half of what you pay to charge your car isn't electricity. Haarlem was worse than Amsterdam, which explains that trip.

At least 12,667 Dutch charge points sit inside a paid parking area. Nobody is doing anything wrong here. It's just two billing systems running in parallel, both working exactly as intended.

The other half of it

While I was digging I found the bit that annoyed me more.

The median is €0.41 per kWh. But most chargers land somewhere between €0.28 and €0.63. Same grid, same electricity. The only variable is whose logo is on the post.

Vattenfall InCharge averages €0.32. E-Flux by Road averages €0.51. That's about 60% more for an identical electron, and you find out after you've connected.

Two invisible variables, stacked. An eleven euro stop and a twenty euro stop look exactly the same from the driver's seat.

So I built a thing

Every public charge point in the country, what its operator charges, and the parking tariff for the ground underneath it. Added together, for however long you actually plan to stay.

It's free. No sign-up, no app, no account. I'm not selling anything, which I only mention because it's a fair thing to wonder about.

parkingnetherlands.com

If you never use it, fine. But check whether the bay is in a paid zone before you plug in. It takes five seconds and it's the single biggest avoidable cost here. And don't drive to a cheaper city, it saves you almost nothing. Picking a different post saves you far more.

Charging data: national charge point register via NDW and DOT-NL. Parking tariffs: national parking register, 323 register-listed garages across 14 cities, snapshot 30 September 2026. Both datasets are published openly on the site. If my arithmetic is wrong I'd like to know, it's my bill too.